

Literary Criticism in the Postdigital Age: Spatial Narratives and Digital Storytelling*

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ABSTRACT: This essay discusses the need to update narrative theories and literary criticism for emerging digital media like VR and AI. It emphasizes understanding space as a key element in storytelling within virtual environments. Traditional literary criticism has often prioritized time over space. However, recent developments acknowledge the significance of space, prompting a shift towards more nuanced explorations of spatial elements in stories. I suggest methods for analyzing what I call “spatial storytelling” and call for collaboration among scholars to modernize narrative theories. Drawing from my teaching of the “Narrative and Digital Media” course in 2022 and 2023, I propose prototypes of teaching tools for navigating stories in virtual spaces. Six general formulas for analyzing spatial elements in both predigital and digital texts are presented as follows: (1) Actions, (2) Interactions, (3) Social Behaviors and Codes, (4) Familiar/Unfamiliar/Defamiliarized, (5) Symbolic, and (6) Affective. These formulas conceptualize how narratives often manifest spatially through human experiences and responses to their surroundings, highlighting the interconnectedness of space, stories, and personal experiences. The proposed formulas also encourage students to read deeper into narrative spaces through metaphors, symbols, and affect. Our culture, marked by growing fatigue with digital media, challenges structures of reflection and critique. Amidst this, there is a call and opportunity for humanities education to reassert its relevance, fostering critical and empathetic engagement with others’ stories. This essay offers one model and tries to imagine ways of making our literary criticism and education more relevant to new media environments and aesthetic experiences in the postdigital era.

Key Words: Space, Spatial Storytelling, Literary Criticism, Digital Storytelling, Narrative Theory

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I. Introduction

Literary criticism has presented various narrative theories, offering theoretical insights and conceptual frameworks. At this crucial juncture, with the influence of new media technologies – such as VR, AR games, the metaverse, and AI – on the rise, there is an escalating demand for high-quality content and compelling storytelling. While previous studies have adapted to visual media storytelling, the emergence of these latest media environments calls for further updates to narrative theories and literary criticism in order to theorize methods and models for narrating and analyzing stories within virtual spaces.

This essay aims to initiate a discourse about how we can retain our expertise in analyzing stories and narratives while theorizing new forms of storytelling within an era where they are increasingly conveyed within virtual spaces. While existing concepts account for the role of space in stories, such as setting and background, our goal is to develop more refined and pedagogically engaging ways to discuss, appreciate, and activate space as an active agent in stories and storytelling. Additionally, I aim to provide methods to recognize space as a critical aesthetic component for enjoying and experiencing stories. As researchers and educators, we must collaborate to offer more compelling terms and methodologies to facilitate this endeavor.

Collectively, we can broaden our horizons and modernize narrative theories to encompass new storytelling realms, including 3D games, mobile games, the metaverse, and AI-generated content. In these novel terrains, space takes center stage in storytelling, presenting fresh challenges in establishing analytical and theoretical frameworks to describe the novel aesthetic and experiential dimensions enacted by what I term “spatial storytelling.” This work underscores the significance of developing methodologies to attend to the diverse practices of “spatial storytelling.”

Drawing from my experiences of teaching a course titled “Narrative and Digital Media” in 2022 and 2023, I aim to suggest some prototypes of

pedagogical tools to teach and navigate stories told in virtual spaces. Ultimately, this essay invites literary scholars to collectively contemplate ways to enhance the relevance of literary criticism and literary education in response to new media environments and aesthetic experiences in today's postdigital world.

II. Theoretical Implications of "Spatial Storytelling"

Let me begin by discussing how space has been studied and discussed in traditional literary criticism. There have been inherent assumptions in the field that time is dynamic, and space (or setting) is passive, with the former considered a more appropriate and serious subject for literary criticism. J. Hillis Miller's trivialization of the topic of space in interpreting literature is an exemplary case of such negativity that has hindered the organic development of the study of spatial form in literary criticism. Miller criticizes attempts to explore spatial form in literary studies by defining it as a "damaging distortion introduced into the criticism of fiction by the concept of spatial form . . . [which] falsifies the actual mode of existence of a novel, the way in which it is a temporal structure constantly creating its own meaning" (46, qtd., in Mitchell 545). Miller makes it unmistakably clear that temporal form is a superior means for interpreting literary meaning than spatial form. This is because spatial form is unable to produce meaning due to its static ("fixed") nature, in the same way that the temporal flow can in a work of literature through its "constant" movement propelling the meaning-making process.

As such, narrative theory and literary criticism have long focused on characters, plots, perspectives, and the temporality associated with plot progression. According to James Phelan and Peter J. Rabinowitz, traditional narrative theory often equated background with the psychological state of characters, absorbing it back into character through implicit interpretive habits (85). Additionally, in some cases, the concept of background has been reduced

to mere description (Phelan and Rabinowitz 85), perhaps due to the perception that background lacks depth and is merely a surface. Laura Bieger similarly addresses this long-standing binarism between time and space, arguing that “changing our thinking about space seeks to emancipate its object from reductive assumptions of time being active and space being passive” (13). Phelan and Rabinowitz point out that “[i]t is only recently...that narrative theory has begun to take up more sophisticated questions about space and setting and to give them the attention they deserve” (84).

A significant attempt at theorizing the role of space in literature can be found in W. J. T. Mitchell’s 1980s article titled “Spatial Form in Literature: Toward a General Theory.” Here, Mitchell challenges the tendency of critics to regard spatial form as a “mere metaphor” rather than recognizing its central importance to the reading experience (541). Mitchell asserts that “spatial form is a crucial aspect of the experience and interpretation of literature in all ages and cultures” (541). Describing spatial form as “an aspect of the literal level of literature” (551), Mitchell defines space in literature as “*the world* which is represented, imitated, or signified in a work” (551, my emphasis). He further explores various scales of space, ranging from “an entire image of the cosmos, as in Milton, or confine itself to a tiny region of the English countryside, as in Jane Austen” (551). Mitchell’s consideration of the worldness and scale of space in literature resonates with recent media interests in worldmaking practices. It also suggests a legitimate approach to analyzing space as a substantive topic rather than merely metaphorical, offering a useful conceptual basis for analyzing spatial forms within stories.

In the twenty-first century, scholars in the humanities and social sciences began to acknowledge the importance of moving beyond the traditional conception of space as merely the background for human activities. They started to pay closer attention to how the role of space has evolved due to globalization and digital technology. Critical attention to elements such as mobility, circulation of labor, digital communication, and the flow of network

capital, along with substantial changes in geographical, economic, socio-cultural, and even cognitive fields, made it both inevitable and necessary to theorize space in new and more invigorating ways. Some radical theories about the potential of space have been proposed as well, with anarchist geography being one.¹ As a natural progression of these scholarly energies, a new term, the “Spatial Turn,” began to gain prominence in the 2000s in the social sciences and arts and humanities.² For instance, a book titled *The Spatial Turn* was published in 2009, confidently stating that “recent works in the fields of literary and cultural studies, sociology, political science, anthropology, history, and art history have become increasingly spatial in their orientation” (1). “[T]his rise in spatial scholarship across several disciplines” (2), as expressed by Barney Warf and Santa Arias, laid the foundation for a variety of studies on space as we see them today. Indeed, the significance of geopolitical and cultural dimensions of space within various contexts, including indigeneity, coloniality, globalization, the U.S. empire, black history, the Asia-Pacific, and others, has garnered significant critical attention.³ In these contexts, the notion of literature as a spatial practice has become normalized.

In the field of literary criticism, some more practical ways to navigate space in literature have been proposed. One example would be a new critical movement called “geocriticism.” According to Robert T. Tally Jr., “[g]eocriticism has become an increasingly significant practice within literary studies over the past few years, even if the exact meaning of the term itself

¹ For instance, see Simon Springer’s *The Anarchist Roots of Geography* (2016).

² I thank my colleague Eui Young Kim from Inha University for sharing and discussing ideas regarding the concept of the “spatial turn.”

³ ELLAK has published important works on ideological constructions of space and literature, including Thadious M. Davis’s “Chaining Black Space” and Robert T. Tally Jr.’s “The Aesthetics of Distance.” Youngmin Kim’s “2015 JELL Forum on Space and Literature” covers a broad range of topics and positions, reflecting the history of scholarly works associated with the study of space in the humanities.

. . . has not been definitely settled” (36). Tally adds, “with the rise of geocriticism, literary geography, and the spatial humanities more broadly, the significance of spatiality has only grown” (37). The “spatial humanities” as a newly emerging field in the humanities encompass all these small or large scholarly efforts to rejuvenate humanities research by paying attention to “geographic and conceptual space” both in reality and in digital worlds and collaborating with “scientific and quantitatively-oriented research,” such as the area of the digital humanities (Bodenhamer et al. I-II). In my mind, these efforts are also aimed at keeping studies of literature fresh and relevant in the digitized world and for students who inhabit it. Not surprisingly, these practically motivated approaches coincide with the widened scope of literary criticism—from written texts to visual texts, and to more recent digital and interactive media where stories are told through various digital spaces. I align myself with these groups of scholars who utilize the topic of space to discover new values in reading literature and to harness students’ experiences in their digitalized everyday aesthetic lives.

The field of narrative theory has also begun to theorize ways to analyze texts (both predigital and digital) using spatial terms. *Teaching Narrative Theory* was published by the Modern Language Association (MLA) in 2010, offering valuable chapters on space and narrative worlds. Those chapters also provide timely concepts, such as “storyworlds” and “worldmaking practices,” demonstrating how considering space in literature can help us understand the structure of stories in different media environments (Herman 124). David Herman suggests that an effective way to enable students to understand narrative worlds is first to encourage them to “take up residence” in the worlds that texts open up for us each time we interpret a text (125). Herman introduces Marie-Laure Ryan’s theory of narrative space about the construction of space and worldview within an actual text. Ryan presents useful ways to understand the movements of characters and plots spatially through the concepts such as “base worlds,” “the world of origin,” “satellite worlds,” and

“the target world” (127-28). According to Ryan’s formula, characters are situated in the physical space of reality (“base worlds”), and around them revolve “satellite worlds” containing their wishes and intentions (what she also calls “wish worlds and intention worlds” [128]). In recounting how he conceived of his short story “Tower of Babylon,” Ted Chiang testifies to the significance of space in storytelling: “The original legend is about the consequences of defying God. For me, however, the tale conjured up images of a fantastic city in the sky, reminiscent of Magritte’s *Castle of the Pyrenees*. I was captivated by the audacity of such a vision, and started wondering what life in such a city would be like” (275). Chiang’s remarks suggest that sometimes, space precedes a story and the fictional lives that will populate it. It is also implied here that our imagination is, in part, spatial.

While existing theories have made various attempts to account for the spatial practices of texts, they tend to be conceptually motivated, which poses some practical challenges for educators in turning them into pedagogical tools usable in undergraduate courses. While exact definitions are not provided, the term “spatial storytelling” has been circulating lately in academic papers in the field of architecture and in other fields, in conjunction with practical concerns about increasing digital literacies.⁴ The term enables broad applications to both literal and metaphorical senses of space that encompass specific contexts and, consequently, stories. My conception of “spatial storytelling” is not entirely new, but my focus is on accounting for how spatial practices in fiction bring about narrative and aesthetic effects. To this end, I propose ways to make the concept more student- and educator- friendly for textual analysis. These tools are widely applicable to both predigital and digital texts, serving as a basis for imagining stories, like what Chiang did, through the concept of space.

⁴ For the former, Fangqing Lyu’s “Architecture as Spatial Storytelling” and “Museum Architecture as Spatial Storytelling of Historical Time.” For the latter, see Asim Hameed and Andrew Perks’s “Spatial Storytelling,” Trevor M. Harris et al.’s “Humanities GIS,” and Emma Slayton and Jessica G. Benner’s “Using Spatial Storytelling as an Approach to Teaching GIS” as exemplary cases.

III. Teaching “Spatial Storytelling” in the Classroom

The latest research on storytelling extends beyond the field of literature; it is actively conducted in design and architecture. In these fields, space inevitably precedes the narrative, but we can learn a lot from them to convey the story through space. Ryan contends that “[w]hile narratologists are best equipped to deal with [space as an object of representation], geographers can make significant contributions to narratology by drawing attention to the environment in which narrative is physically deployed” (1). Studies on digital media actively explore the relationship between space and storytelling. In digital media, space is what enables “dwellers” to enjoy stories via sensory and embodied experiences. For example, the study of narratives in mobile media, pioneered by James Farman, the founder of “Mobile Interface Theory,” is a prominent example. In Farman’s words, “many discussions of emerging media tend to focus on the device rather than the embodied and spatial actions to which our devices contribute,” emphasizing the need to “elaborate on the practice of mobile media and the status of embodiment and space for a mobile media age” (2). Farman highlights the importance of understanding our new era through mobile technology, which enables embodied experiences through spatial practices. The same can be said for the spatial practices of digital media.

In *Narrative Environments and Experience Design* (2020), Tricia Austin articulates the role of space in influencing our physical and mental states:

space and built environment not only embody our culture and traditions, they actively shape our feelings, aspirations and actions. Space speaks to us. We interpret our socio-spatial environments similarly to the way we follow literary stories. In other words, we “read” space by collating the cues and experiencing events in the environment as we move around it, and we proceed to form the elements we encounter into stories. We use narrative to make sense of the world around us. However, unlike literary

stories, we “read” and interpret worldly spatio-temporal situations with our whole bodies, not just our eyes . . . In narrative environments, stories are not just overlain on a space; they are embedded in and expressed through form and materiality. (1-2)

In what Austin calls “[c]ultural narrative environments, such as museums, heritage sites and historic trails,” and “[c]ommercial narrative environments, such as brand experiences, hospitality and event design, community brand messages” (2), space is somewhat superior, at least in this context, in making us “feel,” “act,” and “experience” stories than textual descriptions of space. The element of embodiment is key to making sense of a spatial narrative, according to Austin, since we are programmed to grasp the world “with our whole bodies.” Jessica Brillhart, who oversees VR movie production at Google, states the following about VR: “Once you understand the agency of a person and the space that they’re in, once you understand that a visitor is basically being dropped onto a world and has the agency to do what she wants, then it’s really my job to think about how those worlds interact with the visitor that might be there, interact with the participant, but also, conversely, how do I craft worlds that can kind of interact with the person better” (Bucher 9). She further adds, “[i]t’s a lot of behavioral science, honestly. It’s so much about presence” (9-10). Amanda Farough, referring to a chat among Metaverse industry gurus, emphasizes the concept of “storyliving” in the context of metaverse content, calling for a shift in conception when telling stories in VR settings – from storytelling to storyliving. Indeed, contemporary forms of storytelling in virtual spaces emphasize the importance of creating immersive environments that allow those within them to feel as though they are living in those storyworlds, acting as characters or even as storytellers themselves.

My course, “Narrative and Digital Media,” begins with traditional theories of narrative, where the linear progression of the plot – and thus, time itself –

becomes the main topic and purpose of theorization. While Tzvetan Todorov's formula of equilibrium-disequilibrium-new equilibrium provides a useful basis for analyzing various narrative forms, contemporary digital narratives require a revision of the traditional formula to account for the different technological environments in which stories are told, encompassing both temporal and spatial dimensions. Therefore, the course gradually transitions into understanding how space can tell stories much like characters and plots can. Contemporary digital media, such as Netflix, facilitate intense forms of "spatial storytelling." Take, for example, *Squid Game* and its utilization of impressive spaces, including the island on which the brutal games are played, to deliver the show's main themes. Understanding the show's meaning heavily depends on our grasp of its complex strategies for letting spaces tell a significant portion of its story. Analyzing such spatial narratives requires a toolbox to first recognize how space dictates characters' actions and interactions, thus becoming a key agent in producing meaning. Second, one such toolbox will, ideally, help us to understand rhetorical aspects of the spatial structure: that is, spaces used for storytelling are either recognizable or interpretable via their familiarity, while others seem to occupy an unfamiliar terrain. Third, a toolbox will enable us to understand and recognize symbolic meanings and implications embedded in those spaces.

Thus, six formulas have been developed and presented as follows:

- (1) **Actions:** what are the major actions that take place in a space?
- (2) **Interactions:** what are the major interactions that take place or are enabled in that space?
- (3) **Social behaviors and codes:** how does a space affect characters' behaviors given that the space is part of a social body?
- (4) **Familiar/unfamiliar/defamiliarized:** is it a familiar or unfamiliar space?
- (5) **Symbolic:** what is the symbolic meaning of a particular space?
- (6) **Affective:** what emotions does a space mobilize or invoke?

Let me elaborate on a theoretical foundation, not only to justify why we need such formulas for analyzing spatial narratives but also to help students be open to something that traditional tools for literary analysis have not enabled them to see or do. I will then explain each formula to show how educators and students can apply it to written and visual text analysis. First, I explain to my students, who have never heard of the term “spatial storytelling” the following: **Storytelling can often be a spatial form and practice.** On this point, I elaborate by saying that stories take shape in our human responses to one’s place in the world. Being-in-the-world is almost always embedded in stories, metaphors, meanings, and images. Our bodies and the experiences we make in certain spaces are, in turn, molded by them. To humanize all these, I also add that the place you are in, such as our classrooms, for instance, is already full of stories. Here, space provides a conceptual structure for imagining people’s lives in it and their personal and social relationships.

Henry Jenkins’s term “worldbuilding” is also a relevant concept to contextualize these discussions. Jenkins states, “More and more, storytelling has become the art of world building, as artists create compelling environments that cannot be fully explored or exhausted within a single work or even a single medium. The world is bigger than the film, bigger even than the franchise—since fan speculations and elaborations also expand the worlds in a variety of directions” (116). Here, the potential of building a world in today’s media environments is suggested as something that can encompass (is “bigger than”) storylines and characters. Marta Boni similarly points out that “worlds can be considered forms of knowledge *and* forms of life” (13). She adds, “complex world building is a common practice in the current media landscape . . . *worldness* can be thought of as a metaphor or a model” (13). Boni’s statements here provide two useful suggestions for the direction that we can take for our literary education. It motivates us to start fully considering the “worldness” of stories and storytelling – or “spatial storytelling” in my term – in our ways of teaching and theorizing about literary works. Using the

concept of “worldness” both “as a metaphor” and as “a model” seems to provide a very flexible basis and an anchor for refashioning our field to help enrich popular culture. While the term “world building” circulates widely in academic papers and among lay audiences, there are no clear sets of guidelines as to how to materialize this concept for analysis or for storytelling. Hence, my proposed formulas for spatial storytelling fill in the gaps.

The first set of formulas, **(1) Actions** and **(2) Interactions**, is proposed to help students understand that any narrative world is physical for characters living in or occupying it, and also that a space can dictate the movements of individual characters and interactions between characters. For example, the train station located in the Valley of the Ebro in Spain in Ernest Hemingway’s “Hills like White Elephants” provides the characters with a limited set of options: to stay together and drink at a small bar inside the train station right before a train ride in a foreign country. Their movements and interactions are dictated by the contours and purposes of the station: you either leave to depart or decide to stay when the train arrives. In such a confined but public space designated for travelers, the characters have no other choice but to contemplate leaving together or deciding to stay and end the relationship. All other interactions are minimal, for in this place, everyone is anonymous and somewhat indifferent to one another. These two formulas are particularly useful for students who have only understood stories in written form, helping them analyze stories from the vantage point of spatial imagination and people’s movements and interactions prompted by a space.

The formula **(3) Social behaviors and codes** indicates that different spaces often demand different social behaviors and codes depending on the cultures in and for which certain spaces are used. It also provides a conceptual framework to help students elaborate on what specific actions and/or interactions are encouraged, anticipated, or allowed in certain spaces. For instance, one’s allowed or anticipated actions in a playground are different from those in subway stations or cafes. One’s behaviors at home are also

clearly different from those in public places, as the former and the latter are governed by different social codes and different levels of visibility to others. While formula (3) is an extension of **Actions** and **Interactions**, it contextualizes the first two formulas and helps to understand that many of our behaviors are predetermined by what a space is meant to offer to its users or occupants. Some newly created fictional spaces in works of fiction present interesting case studies for us then, as they often defy our human-centered social codes. For example, the inside of an alien spaceship, where extraterrestrial encounters and communication occur in the 2016 sci-fi film *Arrival* serves as a suitable example (although any works of science fiction will work well). Another example is the Squid Game island, where participants have to follow completely different rules and social codes that work only on the island. I believe this formula can be developed further to take into account larger social contexts associated with our identities (e.g., familial, geographical, cultural, political contexts) that a space opens up and formulates.

The formula of **(4) Familiar/unfamiliar** is quite straightforward: some spaces in stories are familiar to readers/viewers, while others are not. Examples of the former are everywhere: I chose mine from both literary texts and visual ones, including homes or hometowns in James Joyce's "Araby," in William Faulkner's "A Rose for Emily," in Netflix's hit series *Stranger Things*, or a high school in *13 Reasons Why*. Examples of unfamiliar spaces are numerous as well. Fantasy landscapes, such as castles from Gothic fiction, game worlds, and the metaverse worlds, provide us with exotic, adventurous, and immersive environments. I highlight that there is a rhetorical side to one's perception of space. Depending on our experience in, familiarity with, a space, our imagination brings up memories associated with that space. We have certain memories of some unfamiliar spaces, too, such as outer space, fantasy worlds, and exotic places, from our readings about them. Here, we can also bring in discussions about **genre**, if helpful, and how much certain genres rely heavily on the particularities of their spatial configurations through which a

story's main themes and affects are communicated. Gothic, Fantasy, Sci-fi genres are great examples to show (1) how spaces are key in helping readers/audiences to make sense of stories' ambiances and meanings, and (2) how writers use our expectations of those genres' spatialities to shape recognizable plots emerging from those spaces. My students found the **Familiar/unfamiliar** very useful, as it suggests that one's recognition of a space can become a depository of many stories that can come from their own memories of people's actions and interactions in it, and expected ambiances.

I also introduce the concept of **Defamiliarization** alongside the **Familiar/unfamiliar** dynamic to help students understand how works of fiction use readers' and viewers' expectations about certain spaces and purposefully *bend* them for dramatic effects. Some good examples can be found in Netflix original series, such as the "upside-down" in *Stranger Things*—where a familiar American suburb called Hawkins is literally turned upside down and into a grotesque version of itself—and the game worlds in *Squid Game*, where familiar playgrounds from our childhood memories are transformed into bloody battlegrounds, illustrate this concept vividly. These instances of defamiliarization evoke feelings shock, horror, and the uncanny. Additionally, if found useful, Sigmund Freud's concept of the "unheimlich" (the uncanny) can be introduced to explain how familiar objects and places can be transformed into something terrifying, unfamiliar, and strange.

The concept of familiar spaces defamiliarized was favorably received by students majoring in literature, particularly those who are experienced and find pleasure in discovering subtler and more nuanced textual movements. They were able to find numerous examples of written and visual texts where stories become truly intriguing when familiar spaces are defamiliarized in contemporary media. Also, the concept of defamiliarization proved genuinely useful when students devised plots for metaverse storytelling as part of their final projects. In my 2023 course, students participated in a library competition at Inha University for content creation using the metaverse map of the library.

Many applied the concept of familiar space defamiliarized for this occasion, basing their stories on the familiar space of the campus library. One group devised a story about students being trapped and murdered by a “University Ghost” in the digital world, thus turning the all-too-familiar space of the library for studying and reading into a site of terror (Figure 1.). This reimagining effectively turned the realm of realism into a storyworld of gothic horror.



Fig. 1. “Scenes of A Ghost in the Library,”
Kangaroo Punch, *The Library of Terror*, 2023.

(5) **The Symbolic** is designed to identify metaphors and symbols as part of a space’s configurations in fiction. This formula is useful when analyzing “active” spaces in a story where space means as much significance as other story elements. **The Symbolic** formula captures and helps students identify more elements than what they usually attend to, such as conversations between characters or events that unfold over time. We can return to the example of

“Hills like White Elephants” as a prime case of how space communicates complex symbolic meanings to the reader. In the story, a character called “the girl” often looks at the hills against the backdrop of the station and describes, “[t]hey look like white elephants” (34). As many critics have discussed, the hills symbolize a pregnant woman’s belly, while white elephants represent a precious baby or something that no one wants to discuss (as in “the elephant in the room”). Additionally, the symbolic meaning of the station, often associated with being at the crossroads of life, is linked to the woman’s decision of whether to keep the baby or not through the station’s proximity to the other symbolic spatial objects. *Squid Game* on Netflix also showcases great usage of symbolic spaces. For example, the playground symbolizes primordial desire for competing and winning, thus becoming a major symbol of capitalistic pursuit in the series; the subway station underground signifies class divide; the control tower implies class divide and bureaucratic control (a panopticon of some sort); and many others.

The Symbolic has great potential when used to analyze virtual storytelling, such as computer game narratives or metaverse storytelling. In my course, students enjoyed analyzing the metaverse world of Nike via Roblox, known as “Nikeland” (Figure 2.), where the brand aims to provide a symbolic space where the brand’s core values of “playfulness and inclusivity” would be experienced by, and communicated to, the metaverse users (Rowan-Hamilton parag. 6). We actively discussed whether the spatial elements in the metaverse Nike map met the user expectations by enacting the symbolic meanings they intended. Some computer games with elaborate storytelling require analyses of symbolic meanings that come with their well-thought-out environmental details. I recommend computer games with elaborate storytelling and literary qualities, such as *Detroit: Become Human*, *Tell Me Why* and *Dear Esther*. **The Symbolic** formula is helpful when creating content for these newly emerging technologies as well because there is much room for more potent, symbolic spaces incorporated into the metaverse worldbuilding or game storytelling.

This formula needs to be developed further to encompass various visual elements (e.g., light, depth, height, color, scale, etc.) and explore effective symbolic spaces in digital worlds in more detail.



Fig. 2. “NIKELAND [Air Dunk Legends],” Nike, 2023.

Last but not least is **(6) Affective**, proposed to shed light on how space delivers and evokes feelings (both negative and positive) to provide embodied experiences. The term “affect” may be unfamiliar to students, so it would be beneficial to introduce Brian Massumi’s “The Autonomy of Affect” and explain how our bodies respond to environments, creating an embodied sense of being and feeling. In our discussion, my students and I explored *Arrival* and its scenes inside the aforementioned alien spaceship, where humans communicate with alien beings through an opaque orb-like wall for the first time. The interior of the spaceship is an extremely potent and affective space, evoking senses of fear, awe, and solemnity, while being thought-provoking and visceral at the same time. The capacity and agency of the body in navigating and making sense of the world through its senses are particularly relevant to stories told in VR, AR, and MR settings. The recent surge of

enacted and emergent narratives in game storytelling attests to the growing attention and recognition of how our embodied interactions with space or the environment can generate compelling stories.

IV. Literary Education in the Postdigital Age

The term “New Aesthetic” was proposed by James Bridle, a British designer and programmer, along with a small group of artists and critics, in 2012 at a panel during the South by Southwest film festival. At the core of this newly proposed aesthetic lies “our collaboration with technology, whether that’s bots, digital cameras or satellites,” leading to “a blurring between ‘the real’ and ‘the digital,’ the physical and the virtual, the human and the machine” (“#sxaesthetic” parag. 2). Examples of the “New Aesthetic” from this early group of people include various kinds of pixelated images found in architectural objects, photos, commercials, visual arts, or software. They were also interested in robots and mobile technologies that had changed human life and our aesthetic experiences of everyday life. This term was later embraced by media scholars and given a more formal (and perhaps less cheerful) definition in what they call the “postdigital” culture. It serves as a concept marking “the obscure ubiquity of digital, networked and mobile devices...[that makes it difficult] to make sensible and intelligible the seemingly opaque operations of digital infrastructure, even while invoking an ambiguous gesture of aestheticization” in random websites and internet communities (Berry and Dieter 5). According to David M. Berry and Michael Dieter, “‘postdigital’ . . . covers a wide range of issues attached to the entanglements of media life after the digital, including a shift from an earlier moment driven by an almost obsessive fascination and enthusiasm with new media to a broader set of affectations that now includes unease, fatigue, boredom and disillusionment” (5). In this context, the “New Aesthetic” is intertwined with

this postdigital culture defined by “contemporary visual culture industry and . . . the corresponding obsessive digitality,” a culture that is bogged down by “zones of non-knowledge provoked by a competition for attention and profit” (7, 8).

If we can agree that we are now living in a world saturated with digital media content to the extent that this type of shallowly aesthetized everyday life has been normalized and that we feel tired of such a lifestyle, Berry and Dieter are indeed right in pointing out that “[t]his tendency towards automated and accelerated modes of action complicates and may undermine structures of reflection and critique” (5). Where would then our literary education and literary criticism fit in these contexts? This is a question that we have been asking for quite some time, and this essay is perhaps another invitation to ponder the same question in 2024. The concepts that I have proposed in this work may as well be my responses and reactions to such cultural forces, but they have been conceived primarily in the hopes of making our education relevant again as tools for reestablishing the very “structures of reflection and critique” through our resources and expertise in narrative and storytelling – albeit without the excessive intellectual rigor and prowess that used to be our armor and shield. I anticipate that the shortcomings in the suggested terms and methodologies will be mitigated in the near future through collaboration with fellow literary scholars and educators who share a similar vision.

On a brighter note, I believe our culture also enables a “feeling economy” (Roland T. Rust and Ming-Hui Hwang’s term), where genuine feelings and empathy will become the backbones of our cultural and technological landscapes. If this is true, humanities education is, and can be, the one and only haven for resources through which to make possible such empathic attachments and feelings via stories. To achieve this, one of the first steps maybe is to shift our attention to space.

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Figures

Figure 1. Kangaroo Punch, *The Library of Horror*, 2023.

Figure 2. Nike, *NIKELAND [Air Dunk Legends]*. *Roblox.com*, 2023.

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